this head-on, speaking at length on the many sides of Ram and the multiplicity of the Ramayana in its hundreds of regional versions: both Indian and non-Indian. His speech at Ayodhya was different from the Sangh boilerplate messaging on the temple and Ram on several levels. He mentioned the Tamil Ramayana at least five times, even quoting from it a couple of times. (Tamil Nadu has been a key focus area for the BJP, which is eying the political vacuum left by the demise of AIADMK supremo J. Jayalalithaa. It is hoping for new expansion in a major southern state.) Sikhs, Buddhists and Jains featured again and again as part of the new Ram Rajya's respect for minorities. There was no explicit mention of Muslims, except in a passing reference to foreign invaders who attacked the temple of Ram—though he did say repeatedly that 'Ram is for all and Ram is in all'. It was typical Modi-speak, but the references to the many Ramayanas was certainly atypical of the movement's usual rhetoric. He repeatedly exhorted the audience to chant the name of Ram, but used the local religious slogan 'Jai Siya Ram' (which places Sita before Ram), not 'Jai Sri Ram', which was the aggressive slogan of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement.

Hindutva has always had global ambitions. That day, three of its top leaders—Modi, Adityanath and Bhagwat—chose to dwell on why the message of the Ayodhya movement had ramifications far beyond India's borders, saying it was the duty of the young to spread this message worldwide. Speaking of the 'New India' under Modi, Bhagwat argued that 'in the time of Corona', the world was looking for answers. 'Does anyone have answers?' he asked. 'The world has tried two methods [presumably capitalism and communism]. Is there a third way? Yes—we have a third way. *This temple is just the beginning of the preparation of spreading that message of an alternative way*.' (Emphasis added.)

None of the three spelt out the contours of this third Indian way, beyond the usual homilies about Hindu tolerance and ancient wisdom-liners like 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' (The World is One Family)—themes that Modi and the RSS often refer to. Yet, they were hinting at deeper, more tantalising possibilities.

The BJP and Sangh leaders were clearly positioning India as the fount of a Hindu civilisation as compared to, say, a Sinic/Chinese